

The Rise and Fall of American Imperialism

Genghis Khan, Joan of Arc, Attila the Hun, Cleopatra, Julius Caesar - history is filled with men and women who have permanently stamped their mark on this earth through the act of conquering lands far and wide. Today, we look back on them with awe, reverence, and respect. We create movies, write books, and sing songs with their stories as inspirations; their are actions woven through the tales we tell ourselves and praised as the pinnacle of human achievement. In the years that followed the creation of the United States of America, this sentiment burned strong. While *Liberty, Equality, Power: Since 1863* portrays American expansion during the turn of the 20th century as the indelible actions of a population burdened with glorious purpose, this portrayal contrasts directly with the view expressed in “Fantastic Imperialism” and in modern society, which is one of blatant American pretentiousness and indifferent domination.

In *Liberty, Equality, Power: Since 1863*, two sections unveil the tone of the book’s attitude toward America’s colonialism. First is the description and explanation of the fairs, specifically the Philadelphia Centennial Exposition of 1876 and the Chicago World Fair of 1893. The Philadelphia Centennial Exposition of 1876 was deemed a “defining moment for the middle class.”¹ The fair was comprised of 30,000 exhibits on 300 acres of land, with an extravagant array of buildings and displays. Exhibits included the telephone, the typewriter, and the world’s largest generator, all American inventions that placed the country and its inventors at the forefront of human innovation. As stated in the book, “Visitors were awed by recent industrial, agricultural, and cultural innovations, including elevators, monorails, streetcars, linoleum floor coverings, canned food, and dry yeast. Many Americans also had their first taste of bananas and hot popcorn at the fair.”² Over ten million people attended the fair at Philadelphia, which showed the world, including countries like the UK and Japan, that the US was a powerful industrial power. This sentiment was carried until the Chicago World Fair of 1893, where it was multiplied tenfold.

1. John Murrin, Pekka Hämäläinen, Paul Johnson, et al, *Liberty, Equality, Power: A History of the American People*, Volume 2: Since 1863 (Boston: Cengage, 2019), 484
2. 5 Murrin, *Liberty, Equality, Power*, 484
3. “Fabulous Imperialism! The 1893 Columbian Exposition,” The Pinky Show, Associated Animals, Inc., 2019 (accessed Sept. 3, 2024), <http://www.pinkyshow.org/projectarchives/videos/fabulous-imperialism-the-1893-columbian-exposition>

The Chicago World Fair of 1893 was, as described by the book, a turning point in American history. Over 30 million people attended the fair, just under half of the country's 63 million. Over \$29 million dollars (\$980 million today) were spent constructing its 400 buildings over 700 acres. Brilliant buildings painted in white were designed to focus on the grandeur of the new American society, which had just finished its western expansion and now spanned coast to coast. The “White City,” as it came to be known, was a physical representation of the idealized future for the American people. Visitors viewed new inventions such as electrified houses with washing machines, lighting fixtures, and electric stoves in a time where most people had never used electricity before in their lives. New electric dynamos produced even more electricity than the engines in the Philadelphia Fair, showcasing the unstoppable power of American innovation. Secondary to the White City stood the Midway Plaisance, a strip of buildings filled with displays from other countries and far away lands. Filled with exotic animals, ethnological displays, and exhibits where visitors could view abducted foreigners, trapped in crude arrangements of their native culture built for the pleasure of viewers. For some, the Midway Plaisance was a crude human zoo, but for others it was a way to experience the thrilling and exciting adventures of lands unseen while staying in the relative safety of their home. The book emphasizes the novelty of these exhibits, but does not comment much on its effect on the American population. Instead, it sets the stage for the colonialist fever that sets in, explained in Chapter 22.

While brief, the section in *Liberty, Equality, Power: Since 1863* that explores the actions of the American people after the Chicago World fair says more in what it doesn't say than in what it does. At the turn of the century, filled with the frenzy of American superiority instilled by the previous fairs and empowered through innovations due to the industrial revolution, America turned to land beyond its borders for conquest. In just five years, from 1898 to 1903, America polished its grip on Hawaii, Guam, Puerto Rico, the Philippines, Cuba, and Alaska. Men such as President Franklin D. Roosevelt and Admiral Alfred Thayer Mahan led the charge to quench the thirst for land, fashioning the nation into a political and economic superpower, armed with a first-class navy strong enough to make America's presence felt around the world. Overall, the book *Liberty, Equality, Power: Since 1863* gives a rosy outlook to the US expansion in the late 19th and early 20th century, giving credence to the men and women who bravely pioneered into

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the unknown, spreading America's borders from coast to coast and beyond, filling the space between with novel displays and genius inventions. The book makes it clear that most Americans thought extraordinarily highly of themselves and of their country during the start of the 20th century. This sentiment is echoed in the video “Fabulous Imperialism,” which goes on to explain the subtle message the people of America received in both fairs.

The only thing fabulous about the video “Fabulous Imperialism” is the precision in its analysis of the effect the Chicago World Fair had on its visitors. It briefly talks about the inspiring vistas of the White City before delving into the powerful effect the Midway Plaisance had on visitors. Counter to the book, “Fabulous Imperialism” argues that the displays at the Midway Plaisance was a way to frame the new United States of America in a glowing light by comparing it to the strange and appalling cultures beyond American shores. The video makes it clear that exhibits were made to compare and contrast the height of American values against peoples such as Africans, Pacific Islanders, Arabs, and Indians. The Midway Plaisance was filled with drinking, fighting, and exotic dancers. It was adorned with different religions and different people, positioned in a way to make the Christian, white, and newly technological path of life appear as appealing as possible while simultaneously ostracizing these foreign cultures, religions, and people. The subtle message with the Midway Plaisance was easy to miss, yet profoundly powerful. It sent a message of American superiority to the rest of the world, a sense of “us vs them,” a message to all people that America was becoming the new superpower in the world - a superpower that subdued all other cultures and people under the guise of economic and industrial growth. “Fabulous Imperialism” says it best, saying the foreign people in the exhibits “must have appeared very very inferior, and perhaps even... very appropriate subjects for civilizing and spiritual rehabilitation, American-style.”³

Both of these sources would have us believe that events such as the Chicago World Fair, the Philadelphia Centennial Exposition, and the rapid extension of America's reach through control of far away islands are crucial to understanding American culture. A reader of both could argue that the message of both sources is that the theme of American Imperialism is as core to our country's identity as drinking beer and grilling hot dogs while waving an American flag over our field of corn. Instead, I believe that while America's past was forged by people with this

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mentality, the citizens of this nation today could care less about conquering other lands. This, I believe, is the main driving factor in the difference between the message from the book and the video. The book is written by people examining the historical actions and context of the expansion of the US in the early twentieth century, while the video is the analysis of a modern person walking the physical grounds in modern times. Today, almost all references to the Chicago World Fair have been erased, the large lawns replaced with quiet parks and dirty signs, the grand lakes filled with modern boats, the statues replaced with smaller replicas. It is clear that the mentality shared by many Americans at the turn of the century in regards to the expansion of America's borders has died. People today want to keep immigrants out, much less conquer foreign lands. Political figures fight against long wars in other countries, instead opting to focus on domestic problems. Corporations and industrial powerhouses seek only the next consumer, regardless of their location, and buyers care only about how fast their cardboard box will appear at their doorstep. Gone are the days of American Imperialism, as shown by the way we treat the history surrounding these events. Today, the only instance in which an average American is thinking deeply about foreign countries is in the structure of planning a vacation. For example, I can guarantee that most Americans have not heard of the Chicago World Fair, despite knowing about significant events from that time, such as the first flight in Kitty Hawk or the famous Brown vs Board of Education. For an event that was a "defining moment for the middle class,"¹ it seems as though its effect has all but disappeared in the American populace.

In conclusion, *Liberty, Equality, Power: Since 1863* and "Fabulous Imperialism" give two accounts of the Chicago world fair and give a snapshot of the mentality embraced by the American middle class. While the book embroiders a silvery outline to the imperialist culture held by many Americans, the video emphasizes the undertones of cultural superiority infused into American culture by these fairs. In analyzing the similarities and differences, I found myself of the position that both pieces of media overplay the significance of these events, as the colonial energy that once invigorated Americans has long since died, replaced with an indifference to foreign politics and a society focused on matters only within its borders.

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